



the government. Schools are required to teach proprietary software (at least, some schools are, because they are under the control of the universities that require it, who in turn are controlled by the government bodies that require it). This is wrong. So any government that tells people to teach proprietary software is essentially delivering the country into the hands of a company. The Tamil Nadu government is distributing laptops with Windows to the children. Well, that's delivering the future of the state to a company. It's wrong. I have heard that they have now settled for a dual-boot system. Dual-boot means providing some ethical software and some unethical software. That's like saying

“I focus on showing people how Free Software is necessary for their freedom.”

at a lunch in school, “We will offer the children water and whisky, so they could get to know both of them.” Switching to dual-boot is a step forward, but they must stop distributing Windows. It's wrong to ever distribute non-free software to the public—and when it's to children, it's even worse.

Q What are your views on the Indian developers' contributions to Free Software?

Well, I don't follow that. You see, there are hundreds and thousands of free programs, and most of them I have never heard of. I don't try to keep track of who is contributing what, because I cannot do that. I have other work to do. So as a result, I am not in a position to measure the contributions of people from any particular country. However, I do know of one Indian developer who has made an important contribution. His name is Krishna Kant. He came to a talk I gave, and said that there was no Free Software that could speak words from the screen, and so asked what he ought to do? I said, “Write some.” So a few years later, he came to one of my talks, and reminded me of what I had said to him earlier—and said that he had “written some”. So now he has made major contributions to screen-reading software, which he and thousands of other people use.

RMS and his contributions...

Q What do you rate as your favourite contribution to Free Software?

I don't have one. But if you talk about contributions done by me, I would say, in a narrowly practical sense, it's GNU Emacs. I use this program all the time. If you ask me that of all the things that I have done, which one is most important, it's the launching of the Free Software Movement, and leading the development of the GNU system.

Q Which is your favourite distro?

I am using gNewSense, but I don't want to have preferences between free distros. Until recently, this was the only distro that could run on my computer. However, I am told that Parabola also runs on it, so I will try that.

Arguments related to Free Software

Q How do you convince enterprises to resort to Free Software when they argue that Free Software is not secure?

It's foolish to think that Free Software is not secure. Proprietary software is terribly insecure. But I don't try to convince businesses. I don't focus on trying to convince people to use Free Software. I focus on showing people how Free Software is necessary for their freedom. Others are trying to convince people in different ways to use Free Software—I think that is a secondary job.

Q Most people new to the Free Software world do not consider Free Software mature—for example, GIMP vs Photoshop, LibreOffice vs MS Office, etc. How does one deal with such arguments?

If you don't focus on freedom, if you don't think of proprietary software as a threat to your freedom, then you might consider which software to use purely based on practical considerations. Proprietary software developers are not always incompetent. They don't always do a bad job. So either one may seem better, practically. But if you recognise that a proprietary program is an attack on your freedom, and it's a system of digital colonisation, then you will look at the choice in a different way. You will see the proprietary software as intolerable, and would want to know how you can get free software. So if a free program can do the job at all, then you would find that better. Anything that is good is better than anything that is bad. Once you recognise that proprietary software is bad, you will obviously choose the better program (read: Free Software). I would rather have nothing than use a proprietary program, and that's the choice I make. If there is something that I can do only with proprietary software, I will rather not do it.

Q What would be your advice to software developers and hackers in terms of what to do and what not to do?

The way you learn to participate in Free Software development is by doing it. If you use a program, and wish